my alibis for this very optimistic forecast, it may be useful to first delve into a brief overview of why things did not work too well in the past few decades. University systems from the decade of the 1970s have been oblivious to the true meaning of their role in society. We have—for the most part—focused on blackboard-based teaching, leading to degrees that have very little relevance for the nation's well-being. However, my optimism rests on the fact that, at last, India has a powerful and very practical education policy in place that recognises the importance of the role of entrepreneurship through knowledge-based ideas. I speak of the National Education Policy 2020 (NEP) that has brought in its wake a breath of fresh air and good cheer for India's rather creaky educational firmament. It has been hailed in many parts of the world for its vision and outlook, and rightly so. The policy offers much wisdom in very clear and tangible terms, and it does not sermonise through bland philosophy. What does the NEP really have to say? If I had to sum up in one word the essence of the NEP, then unquestionably that word would have to be 'freedom'. The policy offers enormous encouragement, insight and impetus for growth, creativity and experimentation to educational institutions and associated policy organisations.

The NEP lays the greatest emphasis on undergraduate studies and rests on essentially four pillars that comprise the foundations of communication and language skills, IT skills, data skills and transdisciplinary learning. Coupled with this is a pedagogy that emphasises learning in groups through problem-oriented projects that deal with real-world issues. The NEP further emphasises that the curriculum must be based on the needs and challenges of the society and of the nation. A student is expected to find the drumbeat of her soul through this hands-on learning where she is exposed to the many drumbeats that exist in the real world. Once this drumbeat has been identified, the student shall be given freedom and mentoring to march in harmony with this drumbeat. In this process, the teacher and the blackboard are expected to recede a fair amount so that the teacher becomes a mentor, and the blackboard is largely replaced by the world around us. Over a four-year period, the student can—if she chooses—gain deeper insight into a specialised area or, if she is so motivated, gain credit by following an entrepreneurial route.

What makes me assert all of the above with



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